Pregnant and lactating women will also be entitled to maternity benefit of Rs. 1,000 per month for six months.

- In case of non-supply of foodgrains or meals, entitled persons will be provided food security allowance by the concerned state/UT governments. Provisions for reforms in the TPDS such as doorstep delivery of foodgrains, application of information and communication technology (ICT) including end to end computerisation, leveraging 'aadhaar' for unique identification of beneficiaries have also been made in the Bill. Provisions have also been made for transparency and accountability including disclosure of records relating to the PDS, social audits, and setting up of vigilance committees besides an elaborate grievance redressal mechanism.

SUGAR SECTOR REFORMS

India is the largest consumer and second largest producer of sugar after Brazil. Sugar and Sugarcane are notified as essential commodities under the Essential Commodities Act 1955. The production of sugarcane during 2012-13 is estimated at 334.54 million tonnes. However, the Indian sugar sector suffers from policy inconsistency and unpredictability. The Sugar industry in India is over-regulated and prone to *cyclicality* due to price interventions. Deregulation of the sugar industry has been widely debated for a long time. From a purely economic point of view, greater play of market forces would provide better prices and serve the interests of all stakeholders. The government should come into the picture only in situations where absolutely necessary. Export bans and controls could be replaced with small variable external tariffs to stabilize prices. A report on *'Regulation of the Sugar Sector in India: The way forward'* has been submitted by the Committee under the chairmanship of Dr C. Rangarajan, Chairman of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister – the measures suggested are as follows[*] –

a. phasing out cane reservation area;
b. dispensing with minimum distance criteria;